

Life is as confusing as *Kaminey*. But if you're attentive it throws you clues." That's Vishal Bhardwaj, quickie philosopher, closet poet, sock-it-to-you director and fluent music composer. In 19 years in Mumbai, he's made five movies, with as many false starts as he's had take-offs. First there was *Barf*, an Indo-Pakistan movie that was to star Manoj Bajpai and Sushmita Sen but was shelved two weeks before shooting began because producer Ajay Devgan lost money on *Raju Chacha*. There was *Mr Mehta and Mrs Singh* that went into cold storage the moment its final draft was ready after Aamir Khan decided he didn't want to do it any more. Worse, there was *Julia*, based on the life of Nadia Hunterwali, for which *Run Lola Run* star Franka Potente was ready and waiting in a Mumbai hotel, but actors Ajay Devgan and Sanjay Dutt were not.

But as the 44-year-old Bhardwaj says with a laugh, echoing Quentin Tarantino ("now that everyone is calling me a desi Tarantino, I might as well quote him," he says), "Old scripts are like old girlfriends. You love them but don't want to marry them." A wicked sense of humour, a contemporary vision and a calm acceptance of karma. What else does a director in Bollywood need? Well, a healthy dose of luck, which finally seems to have come Bhardwaj's way. He made a loss of Rs 12 lakh on his first film, *Makdee*, which was rejected by the Children's Film Society; was not paid a single rupee for directing *Maqbool*; made a tiny amount of money for his third film, *The Blue Umbrella*; and made his first decent cheque only on *Omkara*. Even on *Kaminey*, he had to forego 25 per cent of his fees because the film went over the budget.

But his cinematic reputation has grown by leaps and bounds, taking him from the classical Shakespearean tragedies of *Maqbool* and *Omkara* to the muddy and murky bylanes of an imaginative Mumbai where African diamond traders do deals with Nepali druglords, where Bangla-speaking gentlemen fixers exchange fire with Marathi criminals-turned-politicians. The Rs 45-crore *Kaminey*, which has grossed a healthy Rs 33 crore worldwide in the first three days, was written in four months with long time co-writers Abhishek Chaubey, 31, whose own directorial debut, *Ishqiya*, is ready for release, and Supratik Sen, also 31. It's a film that is a perfect blend of the many influences in Bhardwaj's life, part epic poem and part street fight, part Tarantino and part Kurosawa, part hard rock concert and part Sufi song, part cinema and part anthropology. Perhaps it has something to do with the way Bhardwaj played cricket—he was a right arm leg spinner and middle order batsman for Uttar Pradesh. Perhaps it has something to do with the way he came into direction, at Gulzar's behest, at the international film festival of Thiruvananthapuram in 1996, where he first saw Krzysztof Kieslowski's *Decalog* and was blown away. Or perhaps it has to do with his being a music director who has done it all, from playing the harmonium for ghazal singer friends at Pragati Maidan for Rs 200 to being recording manager at R.V. Pandit's studio.

The eclecticism of his life is in every way reflected in his work. Born in Chandpur, Uttar Pradesh, he spent most of his childhood in Meerut, going on to do B.A. Pass at Hindu College, Delhi. His father was a poet and lyricist, which is how he had a connection with music directors Usha Khanna and Laxmikant-Pyarelal. Growing up, his Meerut neighbour, poet Bashir Badr, was a great influence, especially so after his father died in 1984. His other surrogate father, Gulzar, is also a poet, lyricist, and director. So no wonder Bhardwaj feels fearless enough to make the film he wants to.

Beginning as a music director for Gulzar's *Maachis*, he's scored for movies such as *Satya*, *Chachi 420* and *Godmother*. According to Deepak Dobriyal, 33, who was given bit parts in *Maqbool* and *The Blue Umbrella* before his breakout role in *Omkara*, there are three pillars in his life—sports, music and writing—and practice is important in all three. "He never believes he knows enough. It is amazing to see how much he can pack into a day that begins at 6.15 a.m. and ends at 11," he adds. Indeed. He does 30 minutes of *riyaaz* in the morning, plays almost two hours of tennis (composing most of his songs on his way back), and writes every day.

For all that, he's quiet, self effacing and so shy he regards interviews as painful tooth extraction-like enterprises. A great reader-writer, he inspires loyalty rather than fear, and awe rather than trepidation. He's three-fourths team man, and one-fourth skipper. "He expects so much from you, it's scary," says Chandan Roy Sanyal, 27, formerly Lysander of Tim Supple's *Midsummer Night's Dream*, and new born star, after playing the crazed Bengali fixer, Mikhail, in *Kaminey*. "But he's also very giving," points out Amole Gupte, the writer of *Taare Zameen Par* and the surprise Bhope Bhau of *Kaminey*. "He did a lot to restore my shattered self-esteem."

Much of it is because he is essentially a good human being, says his assistant director-turned-casting director Honey Trehan, 29, responsible for pulling off the stunning casting coups in *Kaminey*, from making Bhardwaj's old tour operator friend based in Mussoorie, Tenzing Nima a.k.a. Momo, play a Nepali gangster, to persuading *Parinda* and *1942: A Love Story* writer Shiv Subrahmanyam to play the corrupt narcotics police officer, Lobo. "Only when you learn humanity can you learn filmmaking," says Trehan. And that's not just because Bhardwaj paid for three surgeries for a leg that was broken on the sets of someone else's movie. All that Bhardwaj will say is this: "They're my family. I have no other friends. My love for them is unconditional." So is his success. Entirely on his terms. ■

The Vision Thing

Fearless, brutal, dark.
Three of Bhardwaj's best.

- **MAKDEE** 2002 A dark fable. Redefined children's films.
- **MAQBOOL** 2003 Updated *Macbeth*, relaunched Pankaj Kapur, who mesmerised as Abbaji.
- **OMKARA** 2006 Big budget, big stars, big play, *Othello*. Saif Ali Khan stunned as Langda Tyagi.